

From Frameworks to Practice: Advancing Kenya's Climate Impact Tracking through Collaborative Design

By Francis Okwatch

Kenya is making significant strides in climate accountability by co-developing a National Indicator Handbook and a digital Monitoring, Evaluation, Reporting, and Learning (MERL) system. This initiative aims to strengthen the tracking of climate action impacts across the country.

A recent technical workshop brought together state and non-state actors to refine and validate these indicators, ensuring they reflect both national priorities and local realities. This collaborative process demonstrates how inclusive knowledge partnerships can help nations measure climate outcomes more effectively, ensuring that investments deliver tangible benefits to communities.

Building Momentum for Climate Impact Tracking

The Africa Research and Impact Network (ARIN), the African Group of Negotiators Expert Support (AGNES), the World Resources Institute (WRI), and SouthSouthNorth, through the Climate and Development Knowledge Network (CDKN), are co-leading the development of the National Indicator Handbook and the MERL tool, under the leadership of Kenya's Ministry of Environment, Climate Change, Natural Resources, and Forestry (MECCF).

ARIN is leveraging expertise from the Step Change-funded Locally Led Adaptation Metrics in Africa (LAMA) project and its participation in [the UAE/Belem Work Programme](#). These global experiences, including the adoption of 59 [Global Goal on Adaptation \(GGA\)](#) indicators at COP30, are informing Kenya's efforts to align national systems with international frameworks.

Following the initial workshop on strengthening Kenya's Monitoring, Evaluation, Reporting and Learning (MERL) systems for climate action, stakeholders reconvened for a follow-up engagement to deepen the technical work needed to bring the system to life. ARIN is contributing to this process by ensuring that research and community-grounded evidence play a central role in shaping the system.

The latest workshop moved the needle from diagnosing challenges to designing practical solutions. Participants collaborated to refine draft indicators, transforming climate data into actionable insights that tell evidence-based stories of climate impact.



Group photo during the National Indicator Handbook and MERL Tool Review Workshop held in Eseriani Resort, Naivasha (16th-20th February 2026)

From Discussion to Co-creation

One of the standout features of the workshop was the collaborative review of the draft National Indicator Handbook, a document specifically designed to monitor and measure climate and environmental performance across Kenya. These indicators are intended to form the bedrock of the national Monitoring, Evaluation, Reporting, and Learning (MERL) system, serving as the single authoritative source for climate data at both national and county levels.

During intensive group technical sessions and breakout discussions, experts methodically reviewed each indicator to assess its clarity, relevance, and data-collection prospects. They also ensured these metrics remained compatible with existing national frameworks, such as Kenya Vision 2030, the National Climate Change Action Plan (NCCAP III), and the Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs). ARIN played a vital role in these talks, providing a research- and impact-driven perspective to ensure the handbook captures genuine outcomes and impacts felt by communities and ecosystems rather than just simple outputs.

Stakeholders worked together to harmonise indicator units, clarify definitions, and establish institutional custodianship while agreeing on reporting frequencies and quality assurance procedures. This collective effort ensured the indicators are technically robust and practically applicable for national use, with the built-in capacity to be cascaded down to county-level systems. While significant progress was achieved, some indicators still require baseline data before they can be fully validated. Consequently, participants agreed to convene a final technical session to address these remaining gaps and complete the validation process.



Group discussion sessions

Bringing Local Realities into National Systems

A critical lesson emerging from this process is that effective climate monitoring cannot function solely at the national level. County governments are on the front lines, providing a ground-level approach to climate action and the implementation of national programs. Their direct experience is central to shaping a system that reflects unique regional climate challenges and locally developed solutions. During the workshop, county representatives and the Council of Governors (CoG) underscored the need for accessible, user-friendly tools that allow them to document evidence at the community level, such as ward-level monitoring, community feedback mechanisms, and photo documentation.

ARIN emphasised that community experiences and locally produced data must be embedded into both national and county monitoring systems. By drawing on the Locally Led Adaptation Metrics in Africa (LAMA) project, ARIN shared methodologies for co-creating indicators with grassroots actors to ensure the system captures the lived realities of those most vulnerable to climate change. This approach offers a robust framework for linking community data to national decision-making. Participants explored how to realise these connections by harmonising definitions across governance levels and strengthening reporting lines to ensure local data feeds accurately into national datasets.

Strengthening Evidence for Better Climate Decisions

The workshop also highlighted the urgent need for a reliable, accessible data system to support climate governance and guide climate finance. Many current systems are hindered by fragmented or outdated information, which makes it difficult to measure progress with

accuracy. The digital MERL platform is specifically designed to bridge these gaps by harmonising data across sectors and government levels, enabling more transparent and timely reporting. Once fully operational, the system will provide policymakers, researchers, and partners with the evidence needed to identify successful interventions and direct investments where they are most required.

Looking Ahead



Dr Selly Kimosop, Environment Secretary at MECCE, representing the Principal Secretary for the State Department for Environment and Climate Change.

Kenya's efforts toward strengthening its monitoring systems illustrate how collaborative design can build tools that are both technically sound and grounded in reality. The next phase will focus on finalising the Indicator Handbook and continuing the development of the digital MERL platform. Technical working groups will continue to collaborate with partners, including SouthSouthNorth, WRI, AGNES, and ARIN.

For ARIN, this process proves the value of bridging research, policy, and community knowledge. Through the LAMA project, they continue to provide the evidence and regional insights necessary to ensure monitoring systems capture impacts where they matter most. As this work advances, the MERL system holds the potential to improve accountability and ensure that climate action delivers measurable, meaningful benefits for both people and ecosystems.